The Great Empires of Ancient India

Northern India remained under the control of the Persian Empire until the arrival of Alexander the Great in 327 BCE. Within a year, the great Greek leader had conquered the Achaemenid Empire and taken over India. Once more, India was subjected to outside influences, which led to the emergence of Greco-Buddhist philosophy. Buddha was originally known as Siddhartha Gautama and new statues showed him to be wearing Greek clothing. After Alexander the Great withdrew from India, the country saw the rise of the Maurya Empire (322 – 185 BCE) with Chandragupta Maurya (322 – 298 BCE) as its leader. Northern India remained under the control of this new empire until the latter part of the third century BCE.

Bindusara was the son of Chandragupta who ruled from 298 to 272 BCE. He was able to expand the borders of the empire until he had control of the entire sub-continent. He was the father of Ashoka the Great (304 – 232 BCE) who ruled India between 269 and 232 BCE. During the eighth year of his reign, Ashoka destroyed the city state of Kalinga where over 100,000 people were massacred. Death and destruction caused him to convert to Buddhism and he began teaching peaceful principles to everyone he met. Throughout the rest of his life, Ashoka donated great amounts of money to Buddhist temples and towns. However, his generous donations created a rift between himself and his officials. The government treasury was drained so much so that many officials began to withdraw their support. His grandson was a primary official in his empire who opposed him. When Ashoka died, the treasury was empty and the empire began to deteriorate quickly.

India became divided into countless smaller kingdoms and empires including the famous Kushan Empire. This part of Indian history is referred to as the Middle Period and is recognized for its increased trading with the Roman Empire. Also referred to as the Indian Golden Age, the country saw the flourishing of arts throughout its numerous mini-kingdoms.

The Gupta Empire emerged around 240 BCE. The empire was run by Sri Gupta or Lord Gupta between 240 and 280 CE. Lord Gupta is regarded as being part of the Vaishya caste, which is not the most elite class. This is